



in the cold no? Not quite, for while SSDs were getting cheaper and somewhat faster, hard drives were focussed on getting larger, currently to the tune of 2 TB.

We wanted only larger drives and would not accept anything smaller than 500 GB. Why? Well, a Seagate 500 GB hard drive costs around Rs. 2,600, while a 1 TB version is priced at Rs. 4,200, this is a virtual no-brainer in terms of cost per gigabyte of storage space, the bigger HDD wins.

The market is also getting segmented. For example,

Western Digital has a clear demarcation for their drives — Black Editions represent the best performance, Blue Editions represent a mix of performance and price while Green Editions represent power saving.

SSDs represent a breath of fresh air to a category that was becoming predictable, if not boring. They promise to lose their gilded status by becoming more affordable. We already know they have the potential of being really fast, but they're not five times faster, in case you were wondering.

Solid state drives

SSDs initially created a lot of hype, but this has simmered down as people realised that prices are prohibitive. Although SSDs have become cheaper (as has all flash-based storage) they are no replacement for hard drives at the moment. There is the longevity of flash to be considered, for while flash memory itself is longer lasting than traditional magnetic recording, there is a finite number of write operations that can be done to flash memory, or a block of flash memory to be more specific. Exceed this number of writes and the flash becomes unreliable, as does the integrity of the data. Therefore, people who consider SSDs for use as a primary OS drive need to also consider the cons of maintaining a swap file on the drive for obvious reasons. This, coupled with the prices has been a killjoy and continues to be. We were surprised to see Kingston actually offering a 64 GB SSD for Rs. 8,999 — which in our opinion, is pretty good. People demanding terabytes of storage will obviously scoff at the notion of a paltry 64 GB, but for discerning users who want the goodness of flash we feel this is a decent option.

High performance flash is costlier than regular flash memory; although most SSDs will have higher read speeds than HDDs. But the write speeds are often at par, or even slightly below par HDDs, but high performance flash is typically 60 - 70 per cent faster. This makes them ideal for use as OS drives, or a place to install all software. We received four SSDs, three from Kingston and one from Intel. All of these used the same 2.5-inch form factor, although the Kingston SNM125-S2/80GB featured a USB casing. We find

the thought of using an SSD as an external drive quite funny. After all, why take something capable of 150 megabytes per second in terms of read speeds and choke it on a tortoise-like USB bus? Even writes would be bottlenecked, and external solutions are primarily meant for storage, not speed. This drive was obviously made by Intel and rebadged by Kingston; understandable since Intel is a big SSD OEM.

Kingston's SNV225-S2/64GB is pretty impressive, and not just the relatively affordable price tag. We found it to have equally good performance, something rarely seen in any product. It offers pretty good write scores, and it competed fiercely with Intel's SSDSA2SH080G1GN, which was slightly larger, offering 80 GB. Intel's drive was the better performer overall, though the individual results tend to seesaw. The last SSD was Kingston's SNV125-S2/128GB, which was the largest capacity drive in this category, but also lagged behind the others in terms of performance. Priced at Rs. 15,555, this 128 GB SSD doesn't exactly offer much, given the performance. It's a perfect example of a higher density, lower-speed SSD.

When it came selecting the fastest drive, Intel's



80 GB SSD edged out the Kingston SNV225-S2/64GB, albeit by a hairsbreadth. Intel wins our *Best Performer* award for its overall sterling performance. When it comes to